

ICANN, you can't!

THERE'S BEEN AN UPROAR IN THE VERY SMALL CIRCLE OF PEOPLE who care about the world of Internet management, domains, DNS and the like. Most of us don't give a second thought to this aspect of the internet, and perhaps, this is why this issue is filled with stories about things most people don't know about the way the internet works. As long as you and I can click on something and it opens, we don't really care how it all works.

The internet itself isn't considered fascinating, it's the stuff a network of everything allows you to accomplish that brings us joy and satisfaction. Let's hope we are successful in changing that with this magazine you hold in your hands.

Coming back to the uproar... we all know that .com domains are for people looking to run a commercial business. Similarly, .net was meant to be for companies or individuals who just wanted an online presence (short for network), but has since been relegated to the dumber cousin of .com that no one really wants to know about. Then of course we have all the country level stuff, such as .in or .co.in for India, and there is .us for America, .co.uk for the UK, .com.au for Australia, etc. We moved from thinkdigit.com to digit.in in order to show that our focus was on technology in India.

For everything non-profit, there is .org, which is why Wikipedia, the most famous .org site on the planet, uses that domain suffix. The .org suffix (technically called a generic top level domain – gTLD), is meant for not-for-profit entities in every field possible, and is an integral part of the internet. Although we have .edu for schools, many schools have a charity component to them which allows them to use the .org domain. It used to be strictly for non-profit organisations, but since August 2019 even this requirement was dropped.

This change towards allowing commercial entities is controversial in many circles, especially because the internet is used to all .org domains being for charity or NFP (not for profit), and commercial companies can hijack that goodwill. But just a few months later we learnt that Public Interest Registry (PIR), the organisation that manages .org was being sold by its parent company, the Internet Society (ISOC), to a private equity investment company called Ethos Capital. The internet corporation of assigned names and numbers (ICANN) has an agreement with PIR, but cannot force it to stop the sale. Worse still, was the news that it would be converted into a

for-profit model, and start selling .org in the same way .com is sold.

If you have experience with buying domain names, you know that not all domains are created equal – the shorter the name, the more expensive it is. And some of these names can cost several million dollars for the name alone. In fact, it's reported that cars.com cost as much as 872 millions dollars! The ones we know for sure, because the deals were made publicly, include carinsurance.com for just under \$50 million, insurance.com for \$35+ million, voice.com for \$30 million and many more...

Opening the .org world up to the highest bidder takes away from the ethos of .org. Imagine you wanted to start a charity, and had to choose a name based on what domain you could get? Or worse, imagine a charity spending millions of dollars that were donated to it by good people who wanted to help starving children, only to find out that a large percentage of their donation went towards paying for a domain name instead of feeding starving children? And why? So some company somewhere could get richer, because they were too greedy to care about anything except profits?

That's pretty much what has happened, with ISOC selling .org to Ethos for about \$1.35 billion dollars (~ 9,767 crores INR). Obviously, being a private equity and investment firm, that money has to be earned back, and to earn that back from the approximately 10 million .org users out there, you can expect not just the odd domain to sell for millions, but also renewal prices to skyrocket.

Some others argue that the ISOC also needs funds, as it is a not for profit entity as well, and selling .org has made ISOC's future stable and secure. However, the evidence suggests that the ISOC is doing perfectly fine for itself without this sale, and in fact made a change in policy in 2018 to focus on quality over quantity.

It's also wrong for PIR to claim that it will be able to afford more infrastructure thanks to the commercialisation, because a lot of the infrastructure is already discounted heavily – commercial companies giving stuff for cheaper to help them as a charity. It's obvious that operational costs will indeed increase inside the company, but as a for profit, this is terrible, thus input benefits must increase as well. The .org gTLD market cannot sustain huge increases in cost, which leaves operational costs to play with. Expect the downtimes to increase, and reliability of the service to fall, which is what people are fearing the most. 



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